NORTHSTAR
DIGITAL SERVICES

Internal Investigation Procedures

HR ONLY

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Prepared as synthetic content for a role-based retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) demonstration. This document is not an actual company policy.

Access classification: HR ONLY

1. Intake, triage and independence

Policy owner: HR Operations

Confidentiality classification

HR CONFIDENTIAL — fictional training material. Access is restricted to HR personnel assigned to the case and other specifically authorized reviewers.

Purpose

This procedure describes a fair, proportionate process for reviewing workplace complaints or suspected policy breaches. It is a sample workflow, not a substitute for legal advice or a jurisdiction-specific investigation standard.

Intake channels

Concerns may arrive through HR, a manager, Compliance, Security or an approved reporting channel. Record the allegation in neutral language, the date received, the reporting person's preferred contact method and any immediate safety concerns.

Triage

Assess urgency, risk of harm, retaliation, evidence loss, conflicts of interest and whether specialist support is needed. Consider interim protective measures that are proportionate and do not imply a finding.

Independence

The investigator should not be directly involved in the events, have a personal conflict or report to a person whose conduct is being reviewed. Escalate conflicts to the designated HR leader or Legal.

Scope and authority

Define the questions to be answered, relevant policies, time period, people to contact and evidence to preserve. Avoid expanding the investigation beyond what is reasonably necessary without documenting the reason.

2. Evidence collection and interviews

Policy owner: HR Operations

Preservation

Preserve relevant messages, documents, access logs or other records through approved systems. Do not access personal accounts or devices without proper authority and legal review.

Confidentiality limits

Share case details only with people who need them to perform a legitimate role. Do not promise absolute secrecy; information may need to be disclosed to ensure fairness, meet legal duties or take action.

Interview planning

Prepare neutral questions, explain the purpose and process, ask open-ended questions first and give participants an opportunity to clarify. Avoid threats, leading questions or assumptions of guilt.

Fair response

Where appropriate, give the person responding to an allegation enough detail to answer the material concern, while protecting witness safety and legally restricted information.

Notes and records

Record dates, attendees, questions, key answers and follow-up actions. Distinguish direct quotations from summaries and separate observed facts from investigator interpretation.

Digital evidence

Request logs or files through authorized IT/Security channels. Preserve original records and document who collected them, when, from which system and how integrity was maintained.

Interim measures

Temporary reporting-line changes, access restrictions or schedule adjustments should be risk-based, reviewed regularly and designed to avoid unnecessary stigma or retaliation.

3. Findings, action and closure

Policy owner: HR Operations

Standard of assessment

Apply the organization's approved evidentiary standard and relevant local requirements. Evaluate credibility, consistency, corroboration, context and plausible alternative explanations without relying on stereotypes.

Findings

For each allegation, document the issue, relevant policy, evidence supporting and contradicting it, analysis, finding and limitations. Use neutral language and avoid conclusions beyond the evidence.

Recommendations

Separate factual findings from recommendations. Possible actions may include no action, policy clarification, training, process controls, mediation where appropriate, or referral to a disciplinary process.

Decision authority

The investigator should not make an unauthorized employment decision. HR leadership, Legal or the designated decision-maker reviews findings and determines next steps under company procedures.

Communication

Tell relevant parties that the process has concluded to the extent appropriate. Do not disclose unnecessary details about another person's discipline or private information.

Non-retaliation and follow-up

Monitor for retaliation or renewed safety concerns after closure. Document follow-up actions and provide a reporting route if new evidence emerges.

Retention and ownership

Store the case file in the restricted HR case-management repository under the approved retention schedule. HR leadership owns this procedure with Legal and Compliance as consulted stakeholders.